

# Velcro Baby Survival Guide — Action Checklist

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## REFRAME YOUR MINDSET

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- ❑ **Understand Stranger Danger:** Recognize that your baby's distress is a normal neurological milestone rooted in stranger wariness and separation anxiety, not a personal judgment of your bond or worth as a parent. Around 6-10 months, infants develop object permanence and experience your leaving as a genuine crisis rather than a rejection.
- ❑ **Stop Taking It Personally:** Accept that your baby is operating on survival instincts and primitive brain calculations, not making conscious choices about who they prefer. Every scream for your partner is your baby's neural circuits executing a survival program that has nothing to do with your value as a parent.
- ❑ **See This as a Temporary Phase:** Trust that stranger wariness typically peaks around 8-10 months and will naturally resolve with consistent, calm engagement. Your baby is not broken, and this phase is not a permanent verdict on your parent-child relationship.
- ❑ **Recognize the Preferred Parent Is Also Struggling:** Accept that your partner may feel trapped and exhausted by being the person your baby cannot live without. Both of you are in crisis, and acknowledging this shared exhaustion reduces resentment and opens space for practical solutions.

## SHIFT YOUR APPROACH

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- ❑ **Stop Forcing the Bond During Distress:** When your baby is already crying, pull back instead of holding on until they calm down through sheer willpower. Holding them through their distress deepens the association between you and frustration, making the problem worse rather than better.
  - ❑ **Stay Nearby Calmly Without Holding:** Position yourself close to your baby without attempting to hold them when they are already dysregulated, and keep your body language relaxed and non-pressured. Your steady, non-reactive presence teaches them that you are a safe person even without physical comfort.
  - ❑ **Coordinate Hand-Off Timing With Your Partner:** Have your partner hand the baby to you only when the baby is already calm and settled, not already mid-meltdown. Waiting until the baby is already regulated builds positive associations with you more effectively than jumping in during chaos.
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- **Regulate Your Stress Before Engaging:** Check your own stress signals before picking up your baby, noticing if you are tensing, holding your breath, or feeling your heart race. Take a moment to center yourself first because babies read your emotional state, and your stress reinforces their uncertainty about you.

## PROTECT YOUR WELLBEING

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- **Use Simple Redirects With Well-Meaning Comments:** Prepare a calm, factual response like 'She is going through a normal developmental phase and we are working through it' for friends and relatives who make comments that land like stones when you are already hurting.
- **Talk Openly With Your Partner About Exhaustion:** Stop pretending one of you is handling it fine and acknowledge that both of you are depleted and struggling to cope with this dynamic. Both parents are in crisis and naming it honestly reduces resentment and allows you to problem-solve together.
- **Acknowledge Your Pain Without Judgment:** You are experiencing genuine grief and rejection from your own infant, and this pain is real and valid, not weakness or overreaction. Seek support from friends, family, or a therapist because struggling alone makes the spiral worse and you deserve help.
- **Check the Full Guide:** This step is described in detail in the companion guide — open `velcro-baby-survival-guide_v1.md` and review the relevant section.

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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.